Oxford Union-Style Debate Guidelines

For Round Square Baraza Debaters

About the Motion

The motion will be framed as: 'This House would...' or 'This House believes that...'

Two sides:

- Proposition (supports the motion)
- Opposition (opposes the motion)

The debate concludes with a vote by the audience (Baraza members).

Speaker Roles and Time Limits

Each speaker addresses the audience and presents structured, respectful arguments.

1st Speaker - Opening Argument (Proposition) - 4 minutes

2nd Speaker - Opening Argument (Opposition) - 4 minutes

3rd Speaker - Supporting Argument (Proposition) - 3 minutes

4th Speaker - Supporting Argument (Opposition) - 3 minutes

Floor Debate - Baraza Members (Neutral) - 57 minutes

5th Speaker - Closing Summary (Proposition) - 2 minutes

6th Speaker - Closing Summary (Opposition) - 2 minutes

Floor Debate

Begins after the first four speeches.

Open to any Baraza member.

Participants may speak for or against the motion.

Each point should be:

- No longer than 1 minute
- Respectful and relevant
- Directed to the Chair and the House

General Rules and Etiquette

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Stand while speaking.

Address the Chair and the audience, not individuals.

No personal attacks or interruptions.

Maintain decorum and speak clearly.

Stick to time limits strictly.

Points of Information (POIs) (Optional)

May be offered during main speeches (not during the first or last 30 seconds).

To offer a POI, stand and say: Point of Information.

The speaker may accept or decline.

If accepted, the point must be:

- Brief (under 15 seconds)
- Directly related to the argument

Voting

After closing summaries, Baraza members will vote:

- For the motion
- Against the motion
- Abstain

The side with the most votes wins the debate.

Note

This debate format is rooted in Round Square values such as democracy, leadership, and respectful dialogue. The aim is to express opinions thoughtfully, listen actively, and grow through constructive exchange.